

Miscarriage

Miscarriage is the spontaneous loss of a pregnancy before the fetus is mature enough to survive outside the uterus. Miscarriage affects 15–20 percent of pregnancies—the majority occur in the first 12 weeks. Less than 5 percent of miscarriages occur in the second trimester.

Why miscarriage happens

An early miscarriage is usually due to a problem such as chromosomal or structural abnormality in the fetus; a fibroid (a noncancerous growth in the uterus); an infection; or an immune system disorder. Miscarriage occurs more commonly in older women, in smokers, and in multiple pregnancies.

If you miscarry, it's important to know that it wasn't linked to anything you did, such as exercise, sex, or travel. Also, no evidence suggests that rest reduces the risk of a [threatened miscarriage](#) going on to become inevitable.

What will be done

If you have bleeding in early pregnancy, contact your doctor, who may recommend an ultrasound. If the ultrasound shows a normal fetal heart rate, the chance of miscarriage is reduced. If there is no heartbeat, you have a missed miscarriage, which means the pregnancy failed but your body has not passed the miscarriage. In a missed miscarriage, you may not have developed any bleeding or cramping yet. If you have not completed the miscarriage, you may be offered medication to induce the miscarriage or a procedure to remove the pregnancy. Medication means that you avoid general anesthesia and risks such as infection or, rarely, damage to the uterus. You may, however, bleed more heavily and for longer. Another option is to wait to see if miscarriage occurs naturally.

If you have three or more miscarriages in a row, your doctor may recommend tests to see if there is an underlying reason that may increase your risk of future miscarriages. Discovering a cause is unusual, but some rare abnormalities of the blood clotting system are associated with miscarriage.

After a miscarriage

You will bleed for a few days, like the end of a period. Use sanitary pads, not tampons, and avoid having intercourse until the bleeding settles. You could conceive again before your next period, which usually occurs 4–6 weeks after the miscarriage and may be heavier than usual.

There is no medical reason to avoid pregnancy, but it can be beneficial to wait to allow yourself time to grieve and to enable accurate dating.